

especially since it is used by over 80 per cent of Internet users worldwide. Also, most Web sites are designed with IE in mind. Opera and Firefox have capitalised on Microsoft's complacency, and have lured away a significant number of users by offering some great features in their browsers.

The phenomenal rise of Firefox is perhaps what rang alarm bells in the IE labs. Though Firefox has nowhere near the amount of users that IE has, it has risen fast enough to start a new browser war. Opera has thus far remained unique and always ahead of the curve, constantly innovating and bringing in new features.

Features such as tabbed browsing, RSS feed readers, quick access to a multitude of search engines, mouse gestures, etc., have redefined what a browser should be able to do, and Opera has set the bar very high.

While Firefox enthusiasts have been adamant about their browser being the best, Opera loyalists scream superiority, and almost everyone agrees that IE has just been a vanilla browser—until now, that is.

So which one is the best? Whichever we put on top of the podium, we're going to get hate-mail, so we beg your indulgence as we take an objective look!

INTERNET EXPLORER

Internet Explorer 6 is something every advanced computer user has to use once in a while, but simply hates to do so. The reasons can range from slow performance to security concerns. Microsoft had a great deal of work cut out for them to make their browser more secure, and subsequently, acceptable. From our small stint with their Public Preview of IE 7, we think they've achieved most of what they had in mind. As mentioned earlier, what we tested is a beta product, and still has lot of scope for improvement before the final release is out.

Security

To begin with, Microsoft has done a complete ground-up revamp with IE 7—the code has been entirely rewritten! This is significant, because it is the first time in a decade that IE has a new base. Since the biggest



IE7's "Delete Browsing History" dialog

complaint people had with all previous versions of IE was security, Microsoft decided to tackle the problem head-on.

We should note here that the latest version of IE6 that runs on SP2 is pretty secure. It's not the Swiss cheese browser it used to be, though people still have a hard time believing that. The fact is that IE6 on SP2 blocks a lot of malicious sites and pop-ups.

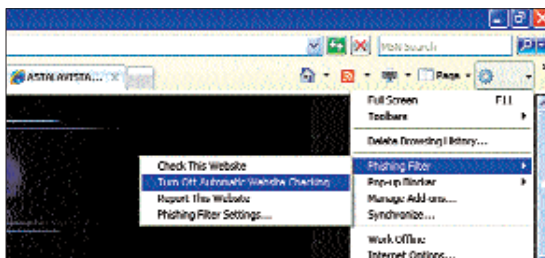
Let's look at IE7, starting with a list of features that boost security in the new browser.

1. Pretty much like what they did with Windows Server 2003, where most services were disabled by default, many ActiveX controls in IE7 are disabled by default. This way, the most common problem of your PC being hacked via your browser is taken care of.

2. A new URL parser is designed to take care of exploits often employed by hackers to create a buffer overflow.

3. An anti-phishing module has been integrated into the browser to offer protection against sites stealing personal information. The browser can be set to automatically check every site, or individually check a page.

If a site has been flagged as a known phishing site, the address bar turns pink; if the site is suspect, it turns the address bar yellow and displays a warning.



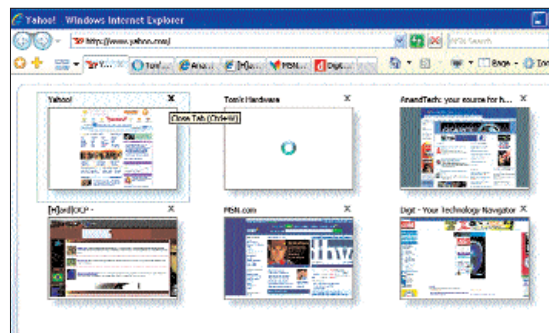
The anti-phishing settings panel in IE7

These are just the security features available with IE7 running on Windows XP SP2. There are more goodies expected with the IE7 release for Windows Vista. Unlike with XP, where IE7 is an add-on feature, IE7 will be integrated with Vista—you won't be able to uninstall it.

Also, in Vista, IE7 will work in protected mode by default—it will be isolated from the rest of the operating system, which means that if malicious content makes its way to your hard drive, it won't be able to mess around with the registry, change browser settings, and so on, unless they are authorised by your administrator account. This also means better parental control possibilities.

Tabbed Browsing

Microsoft's has finally taken a cue from the other browsers on this front! Tabbed browsing is one feature that had been missing from IE for too long. And now, instead of just releasing a regular tabbed browser, Microsoft has added a few features to make tabs more useable.



Quick Tab gives easy access to all open tabs

If you have many tabs open, identifying them is a problem. Microsoft's solution is Quick Tabs—a small icon at the left of the first tab, clicking on which displays each tab as a thumbnail with a small Close icon so you can easily close unwanted tabs.

Sadly though, arranging tabs is not yet possible, and we will have to wait for the final version to see if this feature is incorporated. The new interface doesn't have all the old menus, so you get a neater browser with more real estate to display pages.

The single-click "clear personal information" function (cache, cookies, history, and saved passwords) is also a boon.